

Based on our advice in Chapter Five on defining exactly what you want, you should be able to make three lists that you can send to your agent: must-haves, nice-to-haves, and deal breakers. Sometimes your price range means that you can have it all, and sometimes your price range means you're going to have to make sacrifices. These lists can help convey to your agent what is important to you—and help keep you on track when you see the shiny bells and whistles of an updated home.

Now that you have a crystal-clear articulation of the perfect house—and based on recently sold homes, you know that the perfect house is out there in your price range—you should ask your agent to pull up their Multiple Listing Service (MLS) and search by active properties in your price range. Before you start narrowing down your options, you'll want to see how many are available in your price range alone.

If you're looking at 157 houses to choose from, that can start to get overwhelming—so it's time to start adding your must-haves and nice-to-haves to your criteria to narrow down the options. Bedrooms and bathrooms are a great place to start. (Remember, having two bathrooms is much more desirable than having one.)

Continue to add other items from your must-have list until you are looking at fewer than thirty properties, then ask your agent to set you up to receive these listings via email once per day when you're just starting your search. Spend a few days getting a feel for what is available and at what price, and once you're ready to make a real move, you should change the frequency of your notifications to instantly alert you when a home is listed.

Make a point of viewing your notifications at least every morning and note any properties you'd like more information about. Not all MLS systems are the same, but your agent should be able to look up any address and see whether the home has been listed in the past. Additionally, past listings should have pictures that your agent can review to see if any remodels were completed—which is important for making sure permits were pulled. (More on this in Chapter Twelve.)

Once you've gone through the initial list of properties and chosen which houses you would like to see, set up a time to view them with your agent. Try to narrow down your choices to just a few the first time around—any more than that, and they will all start to blur together by the end of the day.